James "Courtney" Perigo

DATA, ANALYTICS & AI EXECUTIVE

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PROFILE

Data, analytics, and AI executive with more than 20 years in agencies and in-house. Leads the teams that ship production ML platforms, agentic AI systems, LLM features built to a per-user cost budget, and the decision tools executives act on. Trained in Bayesian and frequentist inference, with a record of turning around programs under executive scrutiny and owning an analytics P&L.

SKILLS

Expert in Applied Data Science, Data Engineering, AI & Machine Learning Deployment, and AI and LLM Systems (agentic workflows, MCP, grounded generation). Proficient in ML Platform Engineering, Analytics Governance & Data Quality, Business Intelligence Architecture, and Cloud Infrastructure (Azure, Microsoft Fabric, AWS). Advanced programming skills in Python, R, SQL, Go, and JavaScript. Has hired and developed two 15+ person analytics organizations from scratch.

EXPERIENCE

SVP, Director of Data Science and Analytics
Empower Ocean Media | 2025 – present | Chicago, IL

- Lead Empower's data science and analytics practice, a five-person team of two data scientists, two data engineers, and an ML Ops engineer, and set technical direction for the agency's 15+ person analytics organization. Own marketing mix modeling, attribution, and measurement for enterprise clients including Whataburger, JD Sports, PetSmart, and Sprouts Farmers Market.
- Built a production hierarchical Bayesian marketing mix modeling platform that guides more than $220 million in annual media investment across 50+ markets. Versioned model releases, automated refresh pipelines, and automated quality gates replaced static quarterly studies with continuously updated reads governed by data-delivery SLAs and input standards.
- Turned around a flagship measurement program under C-suite scrutiny. Rebuilt the modeling approach to produce decision-defensible reads in new markets and returned the program from executive escalation to stable in nine weeks. The agency retained the new modeling capabilities as proprietary IP.
- Shipped the team's agentic AI infrastructure: a production MCP server gives data scientists and analysts AI-assistant access to production models and reporting. Version-controlled knowledge systems keep AI-drafted work reviewable and accurate.
- Engineered an asynchronous scenario-execution platform with job submission APIs, a runner service with automatic recovery, and a self-service web app. Planning teams use it to run large budget optimizations on demand.
- Present model findings directly to client executive teams and brief the agency CEO and leadership weekly. Recommendations have informed seven-figure media reallocations, an account defense win, and new business pitches.

Founder & Owner
Empire Sports Analytics | 2022 – present | Chicago, IL

- Concurrent venture. Own the P&L, financing, roadmap, marketing, and customers of a subscription sports analytics product. Designed and shipped its production LLM system, which writes four grounded articles a week per subscriber at $2.33 per user per month with every number computed by code before the model writes; architecture published on Medium.

SVP, Executive Director of Data Sciences
Cramer-Krasselt | 2018 – 2025 | Chicago, IL

- Led a 15+ person analytics organization across the Chicago, New York, and Milwaukee offices. Created the agency's first advanced analytics team and its first production machine learning, and rebuilt the stack so finance, operations, and delivery worked from the same data.
- Launched a curve-fit attribution microservice adopted by 8 enterprise clients. It added $5M in annual recurring revenue and won a 2023 Drum Digital Advertising Award.
- Owned the analytics P&L, including product development and new business sales, and led a 2018 turnaround that expanded agency billable rates by 300%.

VP, Director of Decision Sciences
Publicis, Moxie | 2014 – 2018 | Atlanta, GA

- Recruited and developed a 15+ person analytics and data science organization across two offices supporting eBay, Kohl's, and Verizon Wireless.
- Engineered a real-time Hidden Markov Model that scores millions of daily impressions to identify each Verizon prospect's funnel stage. Won the DMA Golden Echo Award for Best Use of Data.

Director, Analytics
Triad Retail Media, Wal-Mart | 2012 – 2014 | Tampa, FL

- Built a PostgreSQL data warehouse and Tableau self-service dashboards that cut sales report turnaround from 3 days to on-demand.
- Co-developed an omnichannel attribution engine with @WalmartLabs that linked credit card transactions to shopper marketing touchpoints and gave CPG clients like P&G and Pepsi SKU-level ROI on retail media.

Market Research Manager, Mobile Healthcare Solutions
Sage Software | 2010 – 2012 | Tampa, FL

- Authored the product roadmap for the company's first mobile EHR for ambulatory practices, grounded in provider surveys, conjoint analysis, and price elasticity studies.
- Managed the feature backlog around the capabilities research showed users valued, which shortened time to MVP.
- Partnered with Finance on profitability modeling and the multi-year business plan to break-even.

Manager, Analytics
Triad Retail Media, Wal-Mart | 2009 – 2010 | Tampa, FL

- Built the business intelligence processes for the start-up and helped the sales team reach $200 million in annual billings.

Sr. Marketing Analyst
Media General, The Tampa Tribune | 2005 – 2009 | Tampa, FL

Media Planner, Buyer
Doner Advertising, FKQ Advertising | 2003 – 2005 | Tampa, FL

EDUCATION

- **Northwestern University**, MS, Data Science | 2020 – 2022
- **University of South Florida**, MBA, Finance & Marketing | 2007 – 2009
- **University of South Florida**, BA, Advertising | 1998 – 2003

PUBLICATIONS AND THOUGHT LEADERSHIP

- **"Move the Facts Out of the LLM"**, Medium, 2026. https://courtney-perigo.medium.com/move-the-facts-out-of-the-llm-how-a-beat-writer-for-10-000-ballclubs-costs-under-3-a-club-503907dff454
- **"Your Analytics Microservices Have a New Customer"**, Medium, 2026. https://courtney-perigo.medium.com/your-analytics-microservices-have-a-new-customer-6a97d8cc2cf2